on another phone call with Madras. She waited for George to finish his call, but Rajiv Gandhi's personal secretary could not muster up the courage to tell her what had happened on the phone. He chose to rush back to 10, Janpath, where he tried to narrate in fragmented sentences what had happened in Sriperumbudur.

By that time, Congress leaders had started gathering at 10, Janpath. According to some of them, Sonia Gandhi had an attack of asthma as she cried inconsolably. She was not in a position to take control of the events unfolding; no one knew what needed to be done. However, Priyanka Gandhi, her daughter, gathered herself and asked George to arrange for their travel to Madras, where the body of Rajiv Gandhi had been taken.

Reportedly, President R. Venkataraman, upon learning that the Gandhis were planning to go to Madras, advised them against it as the situation was bad. But Priyanka insisted, and some three hours later, past midnight, they reached Madras in a special Indian Air Force plane, only to be told that they could not see the face of Rajiv Gandhi—he was lying in a coffin.

It was clear to Anirudhya why Verma was in such a hurry last night. Sundaram's residence in Pandara Park, which mostly housed senior bureaucrats, was at a kilometre's distance from Verma's residence. Anirudhya didn't get a chance to ask what had happened—why would a CBI officer be called at 10.55 at night unless a raid was taking place? The number of cars parked outside Sundaram's residence was unusual at that hour. Anirudhya had asked his friend what the matter was, but the latter had left without giving him any answers.

Anirudhya went back to typing.

Reports filed by other correspondents on the situation at Lutyens' Delhi were pouring in—so were the agency copies from PTI, UNI, AP and AFP. Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar was on his way back from Bhubaneswar, leaving his political rally halfway. White ambassador cars filled the parking space outside the North and South Block. The PM's secretary, C.B. Gautam, had already called the Cabinet Secretary Naresh Chandra to call a Cabinet Committee meeting. Minister of State for Home Subodh Kant Sahay was in Ranchi when Gautam called. Finding a flight at that hour was not easy. An